

JAPAN ON A BUDGET

7 nights Japan for this summer Backpacker Guide

• Solo travel • Small budget • Big memories



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CHAPTER 0

Who Am I & Why This Guide ?

Hi there! I'm Jenne — a marketing cat wandering across the cities of France, exploring data, growth, and meaningful products. 🐱

I've always been drawn to the kind of problems worth solving — those everyday frustrations that quietly affect people's lives. I'm fascinated by data, product thinking, and the challenge of building things that actually matter. Japan had been on my mind since I was a little girl watching Studio Ghibli films. This year, finally, I went. Alone. As a woman. And it was the best decision I ever made. I love the freedom of a nomadic lifestyle, meeting new people, discovering different perspectives, learning from every place I visit. That curiosity is what drives everything I do, whether I'm on the road or deep in a product brief.

So why did I make this ebook — and give it away for free?

Honestly? It started as a personal experiment. I wanted to understand the people who, like me, dream big on a small budget. Who they are, what they search for, what stops them from going. This ebook is my way of connecting with them — and gathering real insight into what meaningful, accessible travel looks like in practice.

Because behind every download is a person with a dream and a spreadsheet trying to make it work. That's exactly the kind of human problem I find worth exploring — and worth building for.

So many friends had already been to Japan and shared their tips with me. Without them, planning would have taken twice as long. This guide is my way of paying it forward: all the research, all the budget hacks, all the things I wish someone had told me — in one place, for backpackers like me.

Enjoy and bon voyage! 🌸

Budget Breakdown — 1 Week Japan Trip



■ Budget Overview

This guide covers 7 nights in Japan for approx. 1,200-1,500€ all-in from France. Prices are indicative for 2024-2025.

CHAPTER 1

What's In My Bag?

■ Absolute Must-Haves

ITEM	WHY IT MATTERS	TIP
Passport + copies	ID required everywhere	Keep photo on phone
Travel insurance card	Medical emergencies	Check EHIC limits
IC Card (Suica/Pasmo)	All public transport	Load in advance at airport
Portable Wifi / SIM	Maps, translate, pay	Buy before flying
Power bank (20,000mAh)	Long days out	Charge every night
Cash in 'Yen'	Many places cash only	ATM at 7-Eleven
Universal adapter	Japan uses Type A	EU plug won't fit !
Reusable bag (tote)	No plastic bags in JP	Convenience stores
Small hand towel	No paper towels	Eco-friendly culture
Basic meds kit	Language barrier	Paracetamol, plasters
Comfortable trainers	10,000 + steps/day	Sightseeing is walking

✈ Luggage Allowance Reminder

Japan airlines (ANA, JAL) allow 23kg checked + 10kg cabin. Budget carriers (Jetstar, Peach) are strict — check limits before packing!

CHAPTER 2

Where To Go? 7-Night Itinerary

■ Recommended 7-Night Route

NIGHT	CITY	HIGHLIGHTS	TRAVEL
1-2	Tokyo	Shinjuku, Harajuku, Akihabara, TeamLab	Arrive Narita/Haneda
3	Hakone	Mt Fuji views, Onsen, Ryokan stay	Train from Shinjuku ~1.5h
4-5	Kyoto	Fushimi Inari, Gion, Arashiyama bamboo	Shinkansen ~2.5h
6	Nara	Deer park, Todaiji Temple	Day trip from Kyoto 45min
7	Osaka	Dotonbori, Takoyaki, street food night	Train from Kyoto 15min

■ Ghibli & Animation Spots

SPOT	CITY	LINK / INFO	EST. COST
Ghibli Museum	Mitaka, Tokyo	ghibli-museum.jp — Book 1 month ahead!	¥1,000 (~6€)
Jinbocho Book District	Tokyo	Anime & manga paradise — just explore!	Free / shopping
Fushimi Inari at dawn	Kyoto	Thousands of torii gates — feels like Spirited Away	Free
Arashiyama Bamboo Grove	Kyoto	Princess Mononoke vibes — go at 6am	Free
Nausicaa Meadow (Nara)	Nara	Deer roam freely — pure Ghibli magic	Free entry (deer park)
teamLab Borderless	Tokyo/Osaka	teamlab.art — interactive digital art	¥3,200 (~20€)

■ Traditional Experiences — Must-Do

EXPERIENCE	WHERE	PRICE	BOOK AHEAD?
Onsen (hot spring bath)	Hakone / Kinosaki	¥600-1,500	No — walk-in
Ryokan stay (1 night)	Hakone	¥8,000-15,000 (with dinner)	Yes — weeks before
Matcha tea ceremony	Kyoto (Uji area)	¥1,500-3,000	Recommended
Kimono rental + walk	Kyoto (Gion)	¥3,000-5,000 (half day)	Day before OK
Taiko drumming class	Tokyo / Kyoto	¥3,000-6,000	Yes — online
Sumo morning practice	Tokyo (Ryogoku)	Free 'some stables open'	Check schedule online

■ Events & Festivals (Summer Edition)

EVENT	PERIOD	LOCATION	PRICE
Hanabi (Fireworks) festivals	July-August	Tokyo, Osaka, Kyoto	Free (public)
Gion Matsuri Festival	July 1-31	Kyoto — Gion district	Free to watch
Comiket (Anime convention)	August	Tokyo Big Sight	¥2,000 entry
Obon Festival (lanterns)	Mid-August	Nationwide	Free
Tanabata (star festival)	July 7	Sendai / nationwide	Free
Summer Sonic music fest	August	Tokyo & Osaka	¥15,000+

■ Budget Restaurant Recommendations

PLACE	CITY	SPECIALTY	AVG PRICE
Ichiran Ramen	Tokyo/Osaka/Kyoto	Solo ramen booths — iconic	¥1,000
Yoshinoya / Sukiya	Nationwide	Gyudon (beef bowl) — fast & cheap	¥400-600
Kura Sushi (conveyor)	Nationwide	100¥ sushi plates	¥800-1,500
Nakamura-ya (Shinjuku)	Tokyo	Indian-Japanese fusion bakery	¥500
Nishiki Market stalls	Kyoto	Street food — try all!	¥200-500/item

Dotonbori street food	Osaka	Takoyaki, okonomiyaki, crepes	¥300-700
7-Eleven / Lawson konbini	Everywhere	Onigiri, hot food, sandwiches	¥150-400

CHAPTER 3

Budget Hotel Options

■ Accommodation Type Comparison

TYPE	AVG PRICE/NIGHT	PRIVACY	SOCIAL	BEST FOR
Capsule Hotel	¥2,500-4,500 (~15-27€)	Low	Med	Solo, budget max
Hostel (dorm)	¥2,000-3,500 (~12-21€)	Low	High	Meeting people
Hostel (private)	¥4,000-7,000 (~24-42€)	High	Med	Comfort + budget
Airbnb (shared)	¥3,500-6,000 (~21-36€)	Med	Low	Local experience
Budget business hotel	¥6,000-10,000 (~36-60€)	Very High	Low	Comfort priority

■ Capsule Hotels — Top Picks

NAME	CITY	PRICE/NIGHT	NOTES
9 Hours Shinjuku	Tokyo	¥3,200	■ 4.4 — Very clean, women's floor
Book and Bed Tokyo	Tokyo/Kyoto	¥4,000	■ 4.5 — Sleep in a bookshelf!
First Cabin Kyoto	Kyoto	¥4,500	■ 4.3 — Business class capsule
Capsule Ryokan Kyoto	Kyoto	¥3,800	■ 4.2 — Traditional aesthetic
The Millennials Shibuya	Tokyo	¥4,200	■ 4.6 — Smart pod, great location

■ Hostels — Top Picks

NAME	CITY	PRICE/NIGHT	NOTES
Khaosan World Asakusa	Tokyo	¥2,500 dorm	■ 4.3 — Great social vibe
Guest House Waraku-an	Kyoto	¥2,800 dorm	■ 4.5 — Traditional house
Namba Hostel & Bar	Osaka	¥2,200 dorm	■ 4.2 — Party atmosphere
Imano Tokyo Ginza	Tokyo	¥5,500 private	■ 4.6 — Modern & clean
Piece Hostel Kyoto	Kyoto	¥3,000 dorm	■ 4.4 — Central location

■ Booking Tip — Book Early for Summer!

Book accommodation 2-3 months in advance for summer (July-August). Japan is peak season — popular places sell out fast! Use Booking.com or Hostelworld.

CHAPTER 4

Tips to Travel Alone in Japan

■ Cultural Etiquette

SITUATION	DO ■	DON'T ■
Restaurant	Say 'Itadakimasu' before eating	Don't tip — it's rude!
Train / Metro	Queue in line marked on platform	Don't talk on phone
Onsen / Public bath	Wash body fully before entering	Tattoos = often banned
Temple / Shrine	Bow slightly at torii gate	Don't touch sacred objects
Store / Convenience	Say 'Arigatou gozaimasu'	Don't eat while walking
Taxi / Cab	Back door opens automatically!	Don't touch the door
Hotel	Remove shoes at entrance	Don't wear shoes indoors
General	Speak quietly in public	Don't litter — zero tolerance

■ Communication & SIM Cards

OPTION	PRICE (7 days)	DATA	BEST FOR
IJmio Data SIM	~¥2,000	15GB	Data only — use WhatsApp
Docomo Tourist SIM	~¥3,000	Unlimited*	All-round best
Softbank Travel SIM	~¥2,500	10GB	Good coverage
Airalo eSIM (online)	~€10-15	10GB	Buy before flying!
Pocket WiFi rental	~¥400/day	Unlimited	Share with friends

■ Safety & Insurance

Travel insurance: Mandatory! Medical costs in Japan can be very high. AXA, MAIF (French), WorldNomads all cover Japan trips.

Emergency number: 110 = Police • 119 = Ambulance/Fire • Available in English

Embassy contact (France): +81-3-5798-6000 • embassy-france.jp

Japan is very safe: Violent crime is extremely rare. Solo women travel safely here. Common issues: lost items, getting lost, language barrier.

Lost wallet?: Items might be handed in to police koban (boxes).- check

■ Lost Your Passport — Step by Step

STEP	ACTION	WHERE
1	Report to police immediately	Nearest koban (police box)
2	Get the police report copy	Keep it — you'll need it
3	Contact French Embassy Tokyo	+81-3-5798-6000
4	Provide passport photo + ID copy	Always keep copies in email!
5	Emergency travel document issued	Takes 1-3 business days
6	Contact your insurance	They may cover extra costs

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Budget Calculator & Useful Links

■ Estimated Budget — 7 Nights from France

CATEGORY	LOW BUDGET	MID BUDGET	NOTES
✈ Return flights (Paris-Tokyo)	500€	750€	Book 3+ months ahead
■ Accommodation (7 nights)	120€	250€	Capsule/hostel vs hotel
■ Food (7 days)	150€	250€	Konbini + local restaurants
■ Transport in Japan	120€	180€	IC Card + some trains
■ Activities & entrance fees	80€	150€	Ghibli museum, temples...
■ SIM card / WiFi	15€	30€	eSIM recommended
■ Shopping & souvenirs	100€	300€	Daiso, Don Quijote, Mandarake
■ Travel insurance	40€	60€	Non-negotiable!
TOTAL	~1,125€	~1,970€	

■ Essential Apps & Websites

APP / SITE	USE	LINK
Google Maps	Navigation (works in Japan)	maps.google.com
Hyperdia / Jorudan	Train route planner	hyperdia.com
Google Translate	Real-time camera translation	App Store / Play Store
Tabelog	Restaurant reviews (Japanese)	tabelog.com
Airbnb	Local stays	airbnb.com
Hostelworld	Hostel bookings	hostelworld.com
Japan Official Tourism	All things Japan	japan.travel/en
Ghibli Museum booking	Tickets — buy early!	ghibli-museum.jp
Wise / Revolut	Currency exchange (no fees)	wise.com / revolut.com
Weather Japan (JMA)	Official forecast	jma.go.jp/en

Final Words

Japan, Yes, it's expensive if you don't plan well. But with the right preparation, it is 100% doable on a small budget, even working at a grocery store like me ! The people are kind, the food is incredible, and the culture will blow your mind. Don't let the distance or the budget scare you.

Keep in touch with me on Tiktok : @smarterfr



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Go for it. ■■■■■■ (Ittekimasu) — I'm off! ■ © 2026 Emily •

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